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The Quiet Bias in the Booth: How Broadcasters Talk Themselves Into Racial Stereotypes

Turn on any football broadcast for long enough and a pattern emerges that most viewers never consciously register: white players get called smart, disciplined, and heady, while Black players get called explosive, gifted, and freakishly athletic. No single comment sounds like an insult. Taken together, decades of them sound like something else entirely.

That pattern is the subject of a growing body of journalism and research into what scholars sometimes call the "brawn versus brains" divide in sports commentary, and the evidence for it is no longer anecdotal. University of Colorado journalism professor Pat Ferrucci, interviewed on NPR, describes the mechanism plainly: broadcasters consistently link white athletes to intelligence, effort, and leadership, while linking Black athletes to physical strength and natural ability, and Asian athletes to intelligent, team-first play (NPR, 2019). None of these descriptors are individually pejorative. The bias lives in the sorting.

The consequences of that sorting are not confined to the booth. In an interview with WBUR's *Only A Game*, journalist Derrick Z. Jackson argues that broadcasters who consistently code white players as the intellectual ones are, in effect, auditioning them for jobs that come after the playing career ends: coaching staffs and front offices disproportionately draw from the pool of players already perceived as cerebral (WBUR, 2020). A pattern that looks like harmless color commentary on Sunday afternoon becomes, over a career, a quiet gatekeeping mechanism.

For years, this argument rested largely on close reading and lived experience. That changed in 2019, when a team of computational linguists led by Jack Merullo built a dataset of more than 1,400 football broadcasts spanning six decades and ran natural language processing

models across roughly 250,000 individual player mentions. Even after statistically controlling for position and game situation, the researchers found that commentators still disproportionately attached "intelligence" and "leadership" language to white players and "athleticism" language to nonwhite players, along with a separate disparity in how often players were addressed by first name rather than last (Merullo et al., 2019). An Andscape feature on the study noted that some of the largest gaps appeared at the quarterback position specifically, historically the position most associated with on-field decision-making (Andscape, 2020).

What makes the pattern so durable may be that the people producing it do not see themselves in it. A 2021 study interviewing ten sports media professionals in the Netherlands found that while nearly all of them acknowledged that racial stereotyping is a real problem in sports broadcasting generally, almost none identified it in their own commentary (Van Sterkenburg et al., 2021). A related 2024 study went a step further, observing English football fans as they watched matches together, and found that white viewers actively reproduced the same racialized framing in their own running commentary, suggesting the bias does not stop at the broadcast booth but travels into the living room (Van Sterkenburg & Walder, 2024).

The historical roots of this pattern are visible in ESPN's *Year of the Black Quarterback*, a television special tracing the decades in which Black players were formally barred from quarterback, center, and linebacker, the positions considered, in Hall of Famer Warren Moon's words, the "thinking" spots on the field. What once operated as explicit roster policy has since migrated into the more diffuse, harder-to-name territory of broadcast language. The exclusion is no longer written into any rulebook. It survives instead in adjectives.

Conversations with people outside the research literature suggest the pattern is bigger than football. A former high school wide receiver recalled coaches praising his "burst" and "explosiveness" while reserving "high football IQ" for a far less productive white quarterback on the same roster. A middle school teacher noted that the same intelligence-versus-athleticism framing shows up in how teachers describe students, not just how announcers describe athletes. And a club volleyball coach pointed out an unmistakable gap in the existing research: virtually

every study on this subject examines men's sports, leaving open the question of whether, or how, the same pattern operates in commentary on women's athletics.

That gap points to where this line of inquiry goes next. The mechanism by which broadcasters assign competence along racial lines is now well documented in men's football, across six decades of data and multiple independent methods. Whether the same mechanism holds for other sports, other genders, and other media entirely, remains one of the more promising unanswered questions in this line of research.

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